Engage

UX/UI design and prototype

Design decisions, screens, design system and a usability test plan for Engage, the meeting engagement layer that runs beside any video meeting. Companion to the clickable prototype.

Date	13 October 2026
Status	Draft for review. Designs are prototyped. Nothing is validated with users yet.
Primary device	Laptop, second window beside the meeting
Prototype	docs/design/prototype/index.html (also published as a private page)

1. SCOPE AND STATUS

What this covers

This package designs the parts of Engage that are planned but not built, documents the design system the built app already uses, and sets out how to test it with people.

Area	What exists	Status
Built screens	Landing, host console, join, attendee live and games, summary, recap. Running in the app	Built
Floating mini window	Pill, card and presenting states, first-use sharing note, dragging	Prototyped
Recall check	Attendee flow with "Missed that", host launcher and live results	Prototyped
Agenda segments and coach summary	Host chart by segment, segment detail, private coach summary	Prototyped
Error and empty states	15 states with copy	Prototyped
Design system	Tokens, type, spacing, components, motion, copy, accessibility	Documented
Usability testing	Test plan with tasks, scripts and decision thresholds	Planned, not run
Templates, agenda editor, sign-in, history	Not designed yet	To design

Two accessibility defects were found and fixed while writing this. In dark mode the primary button had 2.5:1 contrast (white on light blue). The light-theme success green was 4.45:1, just under the 4.5:1 target. Input borders were 1.3:1 against the card. The fixes (new `--on-accent`, `--border-strong`, a darker `--ok`) are applied to the app stylesheet and the prototype. The tables in section 6 show the measured results.

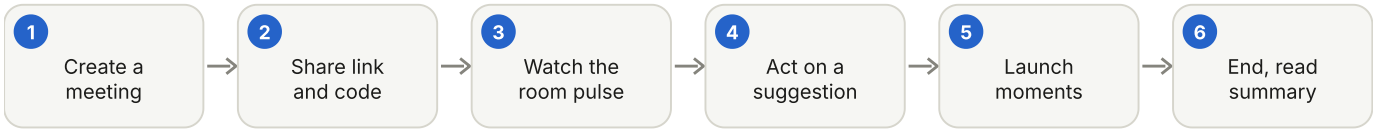
Design principles, translated into interface rules

Principle	Interface rule
The meeting always wins	Everything minimises to a pill. One click pauses all prompts (Focus). Prompts expire and never repeat. No window opens over a presenter
Low pull	No sound, no notifications, no pop-ups over other windows. New prompts add a dot, not a window. One exception: the recall check, for up to 20 seconds, never while presenting
Measure only what Engage can see	No idle, quiet or speaking indicators anywhere in the interface
Transparent by default	The join screen states what the host can and cannot see. Host-only views are labelled "Only you can see this"
Never ranked	Points are private. Results are group percentages. No names beside answers
Zero friction	One click to the next state. Maximum two clicks to answer anything

2. USERS AND FLOWS

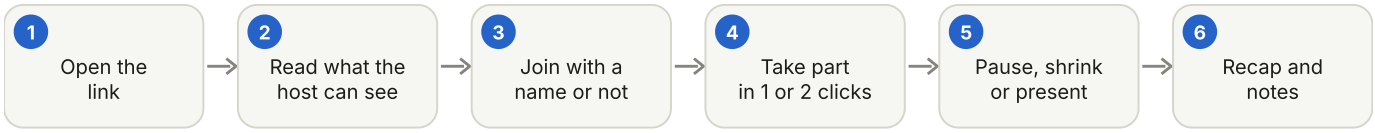
Three flows

Host



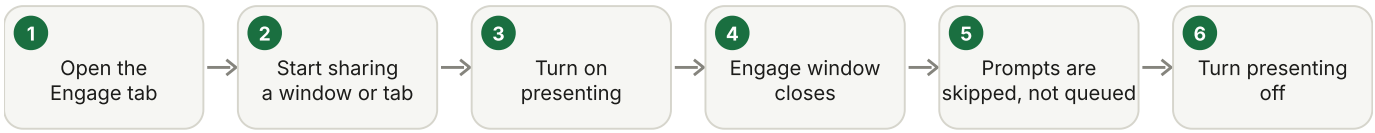
- Branch at step 3: if nothing needs action, the host does nothing. Quiet mode can run pulse checks.
- Branch at step 4: the host can ignore a suggestion. Nothing is sent to attendees until the host acts.
- Focus moment can be used at any step and pauses everything with one click.

Attendee



- Joining takes under 10 seconds. A returning attendee skips steps 2 and 3.
- Step 5: Focus pauses everything. The pill shrinks the window. Presenting closes it.
- Notes and action items stay on the attendee's device.

Presenter



- Step 3 can also be done from the pill before sharing starts.
- Sharing the entire screen would show the mini window. A first-use note says so.
- The off switch lives in the Engage tab, which the presenter is not sharing.

Screen inventory

Screen	Purpose	Status
Landing	Create a meeting or join with a code	Built
Host console	Invite, room pulse, chart, moments, questions, games, quiet mode	Built
Join	Name or anonymous, with what the host can see	Built
Attendee live and games	Prompt, reactions, questions, bingo, prediction, notes	Built
Host summary and attendee recap	After-meeting results	Built
Mini window (pill, card, presenting)	Low-pull attendee view over the meeting	Prototyped
Recall check, attendee and host	Check that the message landed	Prototyped
Agenda segments, coach summary	Turn the chart into advice	Prototyped

Error and empty states	15 states	Prototyped
Template picker, agenda editor, settings, sign-in, history	Setup and account	To design

3. MINI WINDOW

A pill that stays out of the way

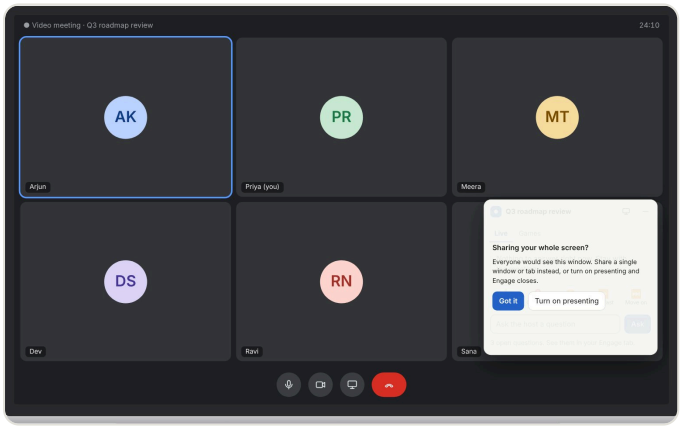
The attendee view shrinks to a small pill in a corner of the meeting. Click the pill to open the card, the dash to shrink it, and the screen icon to close it while presenting. Drag it anywhere.



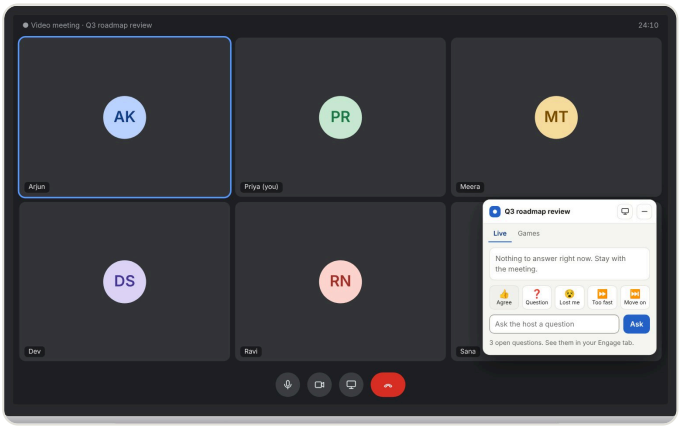
Pill (default). Opens only on a click



A new poll adds a dot and a label. The window stays small



First use: a note about sharing the entire screen



Card: nothing to answer, reactions, ask a question

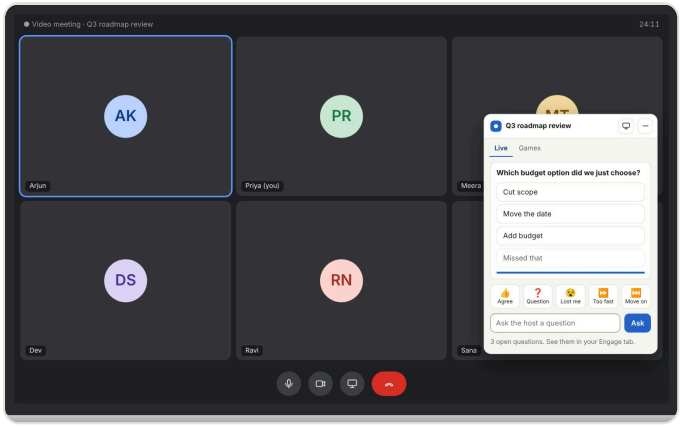
Interaction rules

Event	Behaviour
Join	Starts as a pill in the bottom-right corner. The first time the card opens, a note explains that sharing the entire screen shows this window
New poll, floor invitation, games opening	Adds a dot and a short label to the pill. The dot pulses twice, then stays still. The window does not open
Recall check	Opens the card for up to 20 seconds, then shrinks 6 seconds after it closes. Never while presenting or in Focus. A setting in the prototype shows the alternative (dot only)
Focus moment	Pill shows "Paused". The card shows a dark banner and disables prompts and games

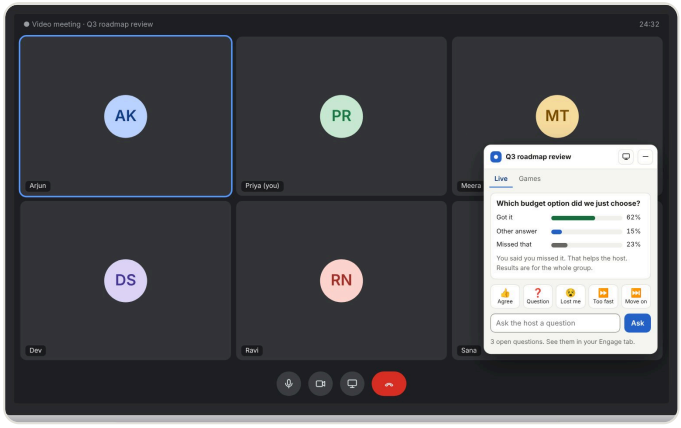
Presenting	Window closes. Nothing shows and nothing queues. Prompts that arrive are only counted ("2 skipped")
Dragging	Starts after 5 px of movement, so a click never moves the window. Position is kept inside the meeting area
Browsers without the floating window	Safari and Firefox keep Engage as a second window. The tab title shows a dot when something is waiting

4. RECALL CHECK AND PRESENTER SAFETY

A check that is safe to answer honestly

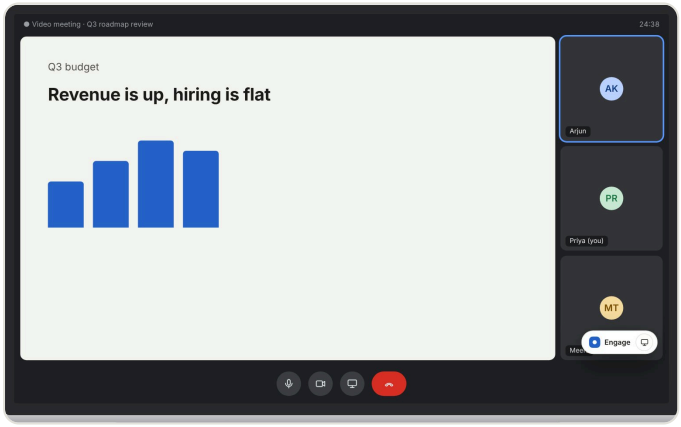


The check opens the card for 20 seconds. "Missed that" is a normal option

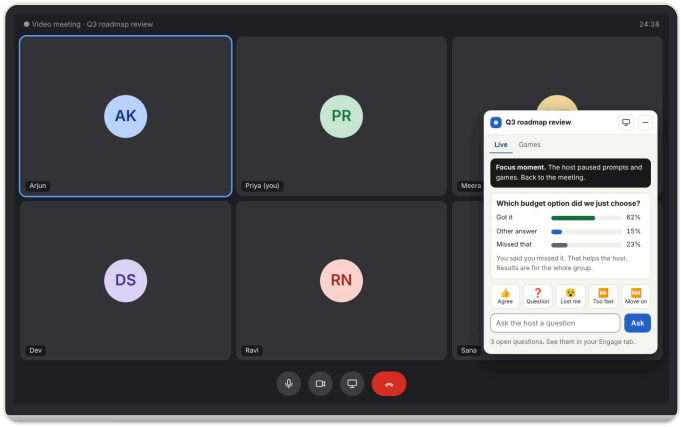


Results are for the whole group, with "Missed that" shown separately

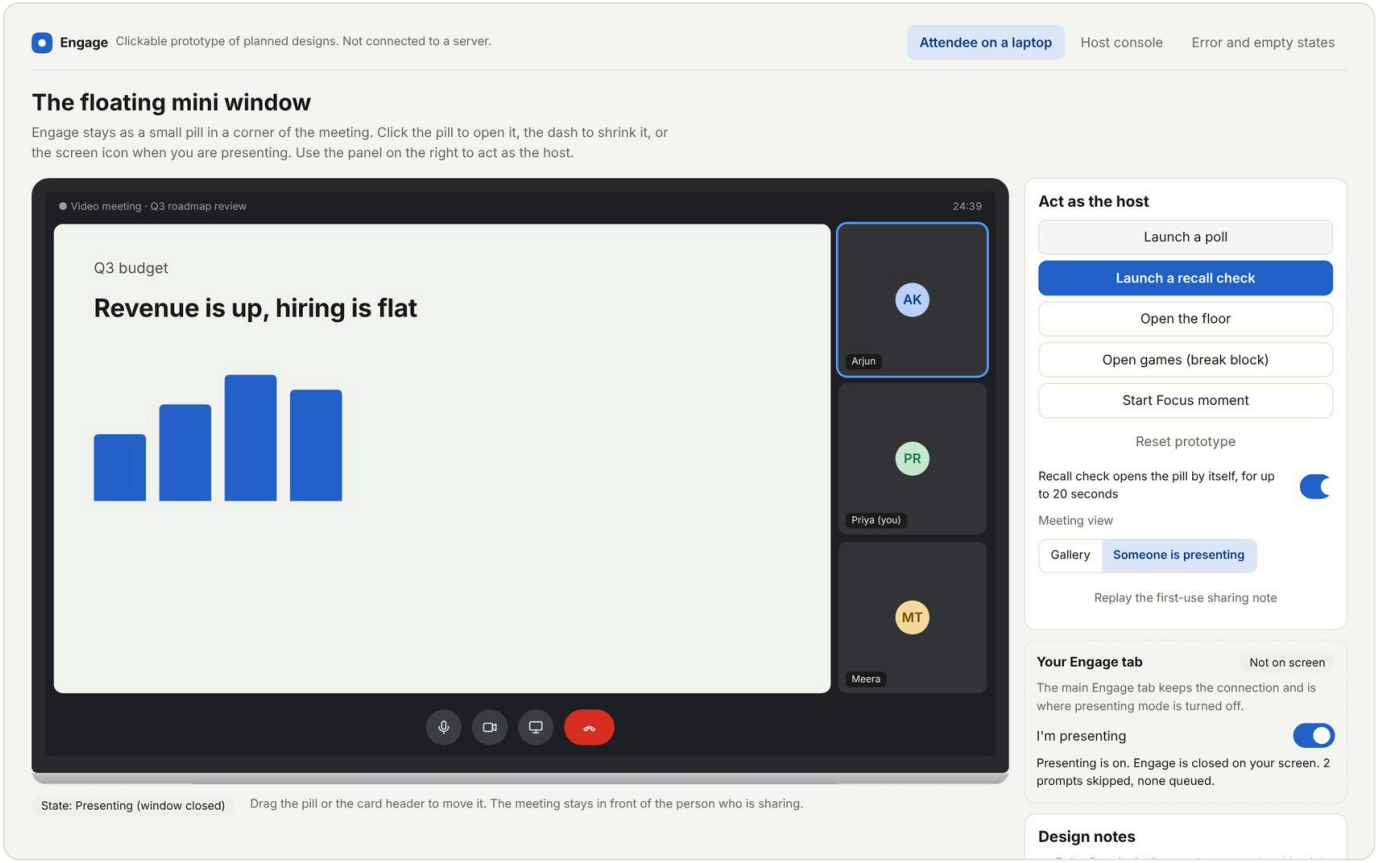
- "Missed that" has a dashed outline so it reads as a different kind of answer, not a wrong one.
- The timer is a thin bar. It is not announced to screen readers each second.
- After the check closes, attendees see group percentages and one line about their own answer.
- The host sees the same split plus a short reading of the result.



Someone is presenting: the pill stays small and off to the side



Focus moment: everything paused, with a plain explanation

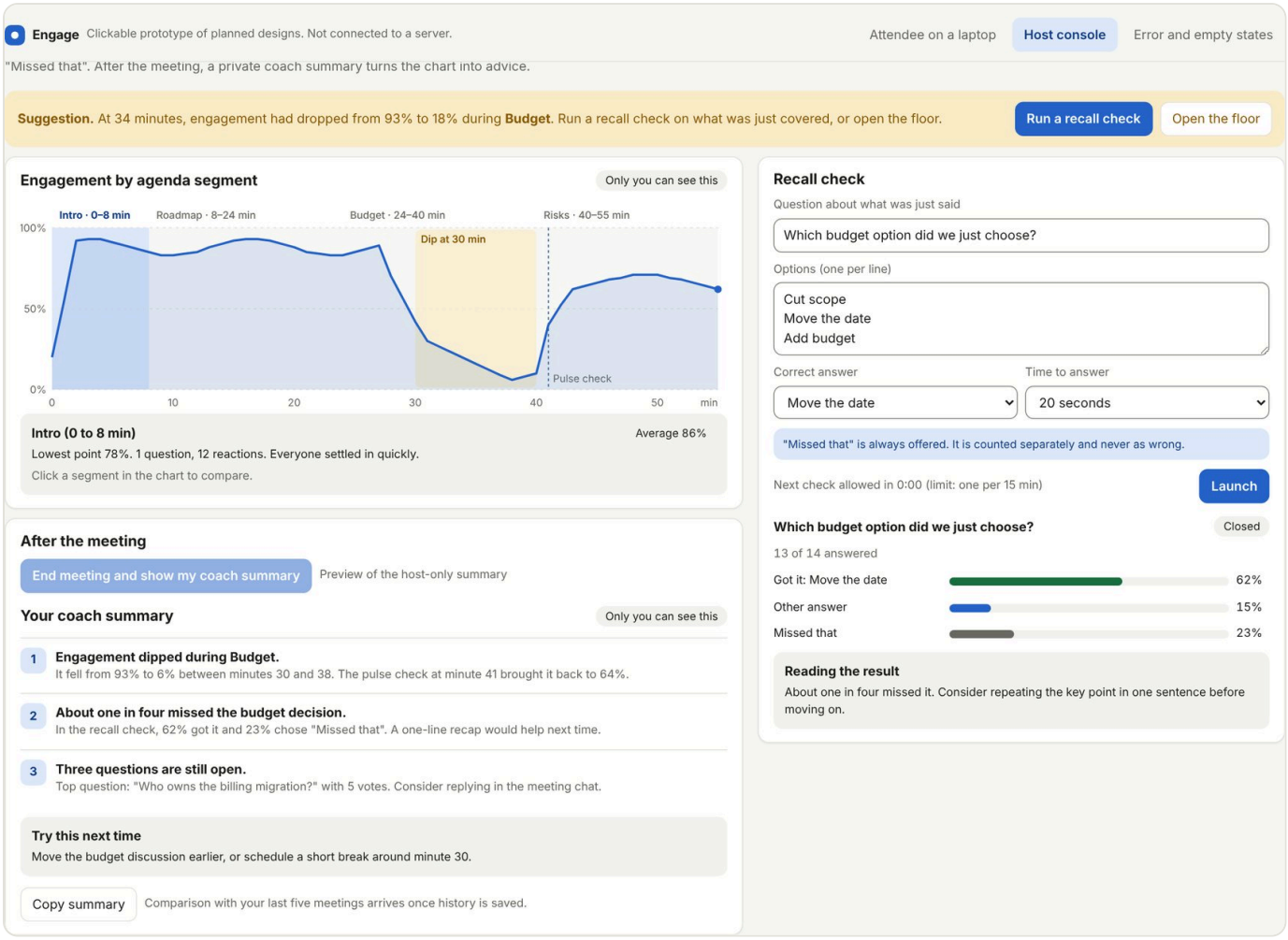


Presenting: the window is closed. The off switch lives in the Engage tab, which the presenter is not sharing

Honest limit. A web page cannot tell whether someone is sharing their screen. The presenting button is manual. Sharing the entire screen would show the pill to the audience, which is why the first-use note exists. Only an in-meeting app can detect the presenter automatically.

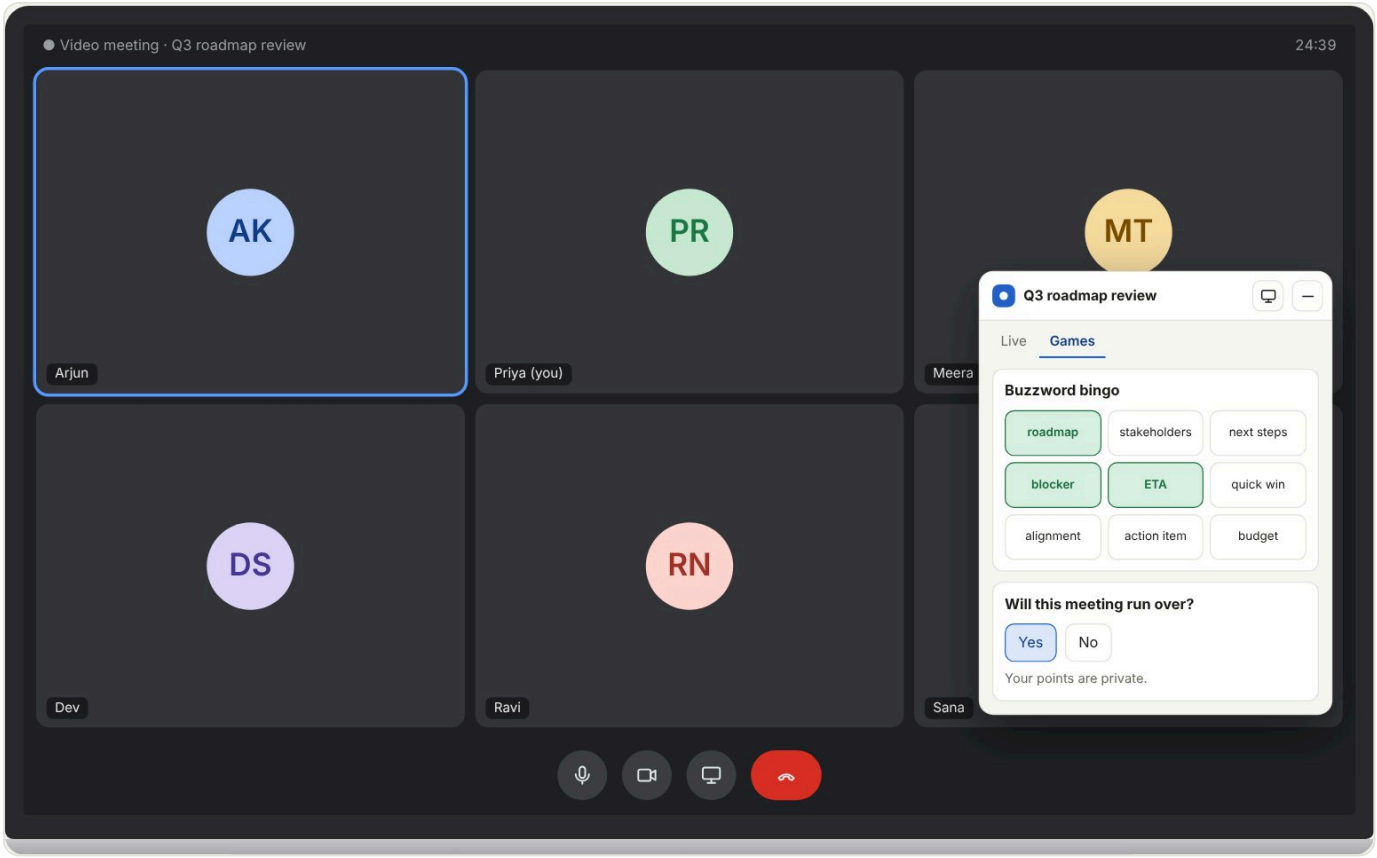
5. HOST ADDITIONS AND GAMES

Turning the chart into advice



Host console: engagement by agenda segment, recall check launcher and results, and the private coach summary

- Segments come from the agenda. Clicking a segment compares its average, lowest point and reactions.
- The suggestion banner names the segment, for example "dropped during Budget".
- The launcher always includes "Missed that" and shows a 15-minute limit between checks.
- The coach summary is private to the host. It gives three insights and one suggestion for next time.



Games tab in the mini window: bingo and a prediction. Points stay private

6. DESIGN SYSTEM

Tokens

The built app already uses these tokens as CSS custom properties in `public/css/styles.css`. Light is the default. Dark follows the system setting.

Token	Role	Light	Dark
`--bg`	Page background	#f6f6f3	#151514
`--surface`	Cards, inputs, windows	#ffffff	#1e1e1c
`--surface-2`	Tiles, hover, tracks	#f2f2ee	#272725
`--border`	Dividers, card edges	#e4e3dc	#353532
`--border-strong`	Input and control edges	#85847d	#74746d
`--text`	Primary text	#1c1c1a	#efefea
`--muted`	Secondary text	#6a6963	#a3a29a
`--accent`	Primary action, focus ring	#2563c9	#6ea2ff
`--accent-soft`	Selected, info banner	#dde9fb	#1e3050
`--accent-text`	Text on accent-soft	#123e86	#bcd3ff
`--on-accent`	Text on accent	#ffffff	#0b1f44
`--ok`	Success text	#1a6f40	#6fd69a
`--ok-soft`	Success fill	#d8f0e1	#173826
`--warn`	Warning text	#8a5a00	#f0c25a
`--warn-soft`	Warning fill	#fbecc8	#3a2f12
`--bad`	Error text	#a3322a	#ff9d93
`--bad-soft`	Error fill	#f8dcd8	#43201c

Type

Role	Size and weight	Used for
System sans	system-ui, -apple-system, Segoe UI, Roboto. No web fonts, so first paint is fast and nothing is blocked on a company network	
Page title	26 px, 700	Landing headline, summary title
Card title	16 px, 700	Card headings
Body	15 px, 400	Default text
Small	12.5 to 13 px	Hints, labels, meta
Figure	30 px, 650, tabular numbers	Room tiles
Code	28 px mono, 600, wide tracking	Meeting code

Space, shape and depth

Item	Value

Spacing scale	4, 8, 12, 16, 24, 32 px. Use gap, not margins
Radius	Controls 9 px. Cards 12 px. Floating window 14 px. Pills and chips fully round
Elevation	Cards use a hairline border and almost no shadow. Only the floating window has a strong shadow, because it sits over other content
Icons	Outline, 1.8 px stroke, round caps, 17 to 22 px

Components

Component	Variants and states	Notes
Button	Default, primary, ghost, selected, danger. Hover, active (scale 0.97), focus, disabled	Primary text uses `--on-accent`
Chip	Neutral, accent, success, warning	Always has text, never colour alone
Card	Default, soft	Border and radius only. No decorative stripes
Banner	Info, warning, Focus (inverted)	One sentence, optional one action
Tile	Label, value, sub-label	Room pulse only
Tabs	Selected has accent underline	Roving focus, role tablist
Result bar	Neutral, success (correct), muted (missed)	Percent shown as a number too
Switch	On, off	role switch, label states the effect
Input	Default, focus, error	Border uses `--border-strong`
Reaction button	Default, just pressed	Icon plus word
Question row	Open, answered, mine	Votes are a button with aria-pressed
Mini window	Pill, card, hidden	See section 3

Motion

- Colour changes 120 ms. Press feedback 80 ms. Result bars 250 ms. Switch 150 ms.
- The only looping effect is the pill dot, twice, 1.6 seconds each.
- Prompts appear without animation.
- With reduced motion on, all transitions and animation are off.

Accessibility specification

Measured contrast

Targets: 4.5:1 for text, 3:1 for focus rings and form control edges. Values are computed from the tokens above.

Pair	Tokens	Target	Light	Dark
Body text on card	`text on surface`	4.5:1	17.07:1 Pass	14.47:1 Pass
Body text on page	`text on bg`	4.5:1	15.76:1 Pass	15.84:1 Pass
Muted text on card	`muted on surface`	4.5:1	5.51:1 Pass	6.51:1 Pass
Muted text on page	`muted on bg`	4.5:1	5.09:1 Pass	7.13:1 Pass
Muted text on tile	`muted on surface-2`	4.5:1	4.91:1 Pass	5.84:1 Pass
Accent text on selected fill	`accent-text on accent-soft`	4.5:1	8.32:1 Pass	8.72:1 Pass
Primary button text	`on-accent on accent`	4.5:1	5.67:1 Pass	6.4:1 Pass
Accent used as text	`accent on surface`	4.5:1	5.67:1 Pass	6.58:1 Pass
Success text on fill	`ok on ok-soft`	4.5:1	5.15:1 Pass	7.22:1 Pass
Warning text on fill	`warn on warn-soft`	4.5:1	5.06:1 Pass	7.88:1 Pass
Error text on card	`bad on surface`	4.5:1	6.89:1 Pass	8.35:1 Pass
Error text on fill	`bad on bad-soft`	4.5:1	5.32:1 Pass	7.18:1 Pass
Focus ring on card	`accent on surface`	3.0:1	5.67:1 Pass	6.58:1 Pass
Input border on card	`border-strong on surface`	3.0:1	3.75:1 Pass	3.55:1 Pass
Input border on page	`border-strong on bg`	3.0:1	3.47:1 Pass	3.88:1 Pass

Defects found and fixed. Before the fix: dark primary button 2.54:1, light success text 4.45:1, input borders about 1.3:1. After: 6.4:1, 5.15:1 and 3.55:1 or better. Card and divider borders stay light on purpose because they are decoration, not identification.

Specification

Area	Requirement
Keyboard	Every control reachable and operable by keyboard. Visible 2 px focus ring with offset. Escape shrinks the card to the pill and returns focus to it (specified, not yet in the prototype)
Screen readers	A polite live region announces a new prompt once. The countdown is hidden from assistive technology. Results are announced when closed. The presenting control is a switch
Target size	Mini window icon buttons are 30 to 34 px, above the 24 px minimum in WCAG 2.2. Primary actions are at least 34 px tall. Use 44 px on touch
Colour	State is never shown by colour alone. Chips and banners carry text
Zoom and reflow	Layouts reflow at 200% zoom. No horizontal scroll down to 360 px
Motion	Respects reduced motion. No flashing

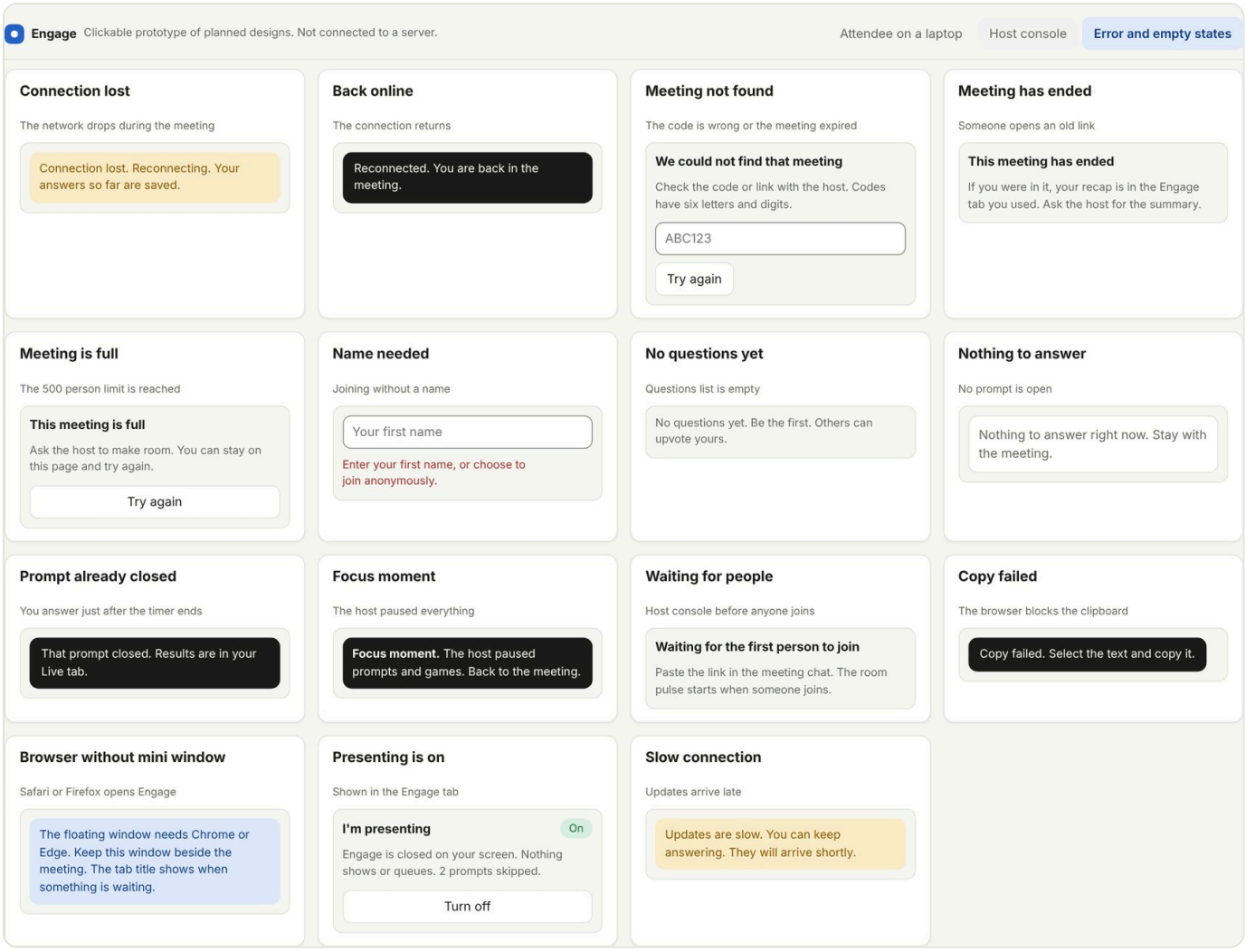
Audit	Not yet done. Run an automated scan and a manual screen reader pass before the pilot (see the engineering plan)

Writing for the interface

Rule	Example
Say what happened, then what to do	"Connection lost. Reconnecting. Your answers so far are saved."
Name things by what people recognise	"Missed that", "I'm presenting", "Focus moment"
A control says what it does	"Turn on presenting", "Launch", "Close and show results"
No blame, no pressure	"Not this time." Never "Wrong"
Plain and short	Avoid "gamify", "engagement score", "leaderboard"
Respect privacy in words	"Only you can see this", "Results are for the whole group"

7. ERROR AND EMPTY STATES

Fifteen states, none blocks the meeting



Each state says what happened and what to do next

States covered: connection lost and restored, meeting not found, ended or full, name needed, no questions, nothing to answer, prompt already closed, Focus, waiting for people, copy failed, browser without the mini window, presenting on, and slow connection.

8. USABILITY TEST PLAN

Test the prototype with real people

Goals

- Find out whether attendees feel pulled out of the meeting by the pill, the badge or the recall check.
- Check that "Missed that" feels safe and that people use it honestly.
- Check that hosts understand the suggestion banner, the agenda chart and the coach summary.
- Check that presenting mode is easy to find, trust and turn off.

Method

Item	Plan
Participants	5 hosts and 8 attendees from different teams. Include at least 2 people who run long meetings and 2 who rarely speak
Format	30 minutes, moderated, think aloud. The prototype runs on a laptop beside a real or recorded meeting
Prototype	Clickable prototype for new features. The working app for the built screens
Recording	Notes and screen recording only with consent. No meeting content is collected

Attendee tasks

#	Task	Success
A1	Join from the link and say what the host can see	Correctly states at least two items
A2	The host asks a poll. Answer it while following the discussion	Answers within 30 seconds without help
A3	A recall check opens. Answer, then say how it felt	Chooses honestly. Rates pressure 3 or lower of 5
A4	You are about to share your screen. Make sure Engage does not show	Finds and uses presenting within 20 seconds
A5	After sharing, bring Engage back	Turns presenting off from the Engage tab
A6	Move the pill out of the way and shrink the card	Done without help

Host tasks

#	Task	Success
H1	Start a meeting and invite people	Shares the link in under 30 seconds
H2	Read the room and say what the banner suggests	Explains the suggestion in their own words
H3	Run a recall check and interpret the result	Distinguishes missed from wrong
H4	Find which agenda segment lost people	Identifies the segment from the chart
H5	Read the coach summary and pick one action	Chooses an action and says why

Questions after the session

- "At any point, did Engage pull your attention away from the meeting?" (1 to 5, then why)
- "Did anything make you feel watched or judged?"

- "Would you leave Engage open for a whole meeting?"
- "What would make you turn it off?"
- Single Ease Question after each task (1 to 7).

Measures and decision thresholds

Measure	Threshold to proceed
Task success	At least 80% unaided across tasks
Distraction rating	Median 2 or lower of 5, and no more than 1 in 10 says "pulled me out"
Felt watched	0 of 13 describe the product as monitoring
Presenting mode	At least 6 of 8 find it unaided
Would keep it open	At least 60% yes

If distraction or "felt watched" fails, change the interaction before building more. If presenting mode is not found, move the control or add a first-run hint.

Open design questions

- Should the recall check open the pill itself, or only add a dot? The prototype has a switch so testers can compare.
- Is the pill's 190 px width too large in a corner of a small laptop screen?
- Do people expect Escape to close or shrink?
- Where should a host set up the agenda: before the meeting, or from a calendar event?